

Jump onto the next bracket nearing the Rs 44,500 to 50,000 mark and we have no doubt: it has to be the Compaq Presario V6102AU—believe us, its refreshing design is irresistible, and the superb performance just adds another feather to its cap. It's clearly above the competition, but do keep in mind its low battery life and slight heating issues. Our Silver award goes to the ACi Ethos Duo 1430, because of its overall performance and features.

## THE USUAL SUSPECTS

The largest category, with 13 laptops, is designed to brave the daily grind. Endurance apart, these laptops sported some of the best lookers, and the most well-configured of the lot. Heavyweights such as Dell, Toshiba, LG, and HP had one model each competing for the award, as did ASUS, MSI, Gigabyte, and TCL. The contenders are the Asus Z35H, ASUS V6000J, MSI Megabook S425, Gigabyte W551N, Gigabyte W511U, Toshiba Tecra A8, Toshiba Satellite L100, LG XNote T1, LG XNote P1, Dell Inspiron 6400, Dell Inspiron 640m, TCL K41, and the HP Pavilion dv2025TU.

## Features

### Look and Feel

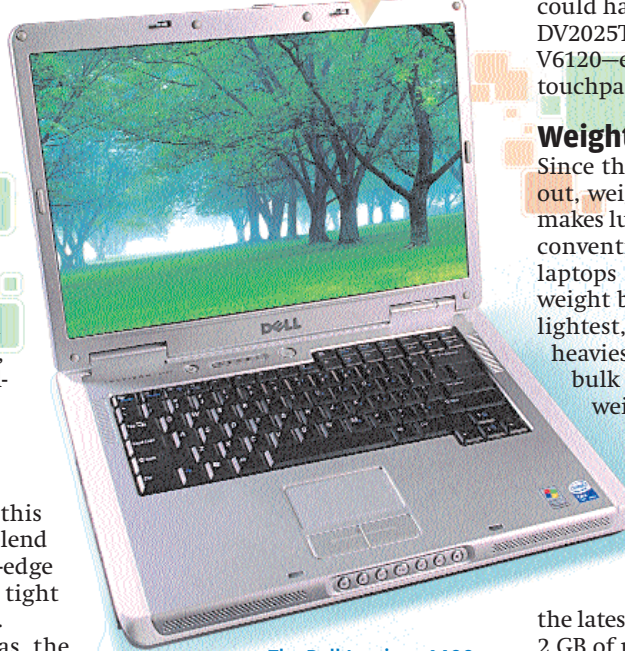
The laptops that fall in this segment are designed to blend aesthetics with cutting-edge performance, keeping a tight check on weight and size.

The ASUS V6000J was the best looking of them all. Sporting a metallic body with a brushed aluminium finish, the design is sumptuous. Intelligent use of blue for backlighting certain buttons, switches, and the touchpad gives the V6000 its distinctive character. The ASUS Z35H, on the other hand, is the opposite: it sports a completely silver body—uninspiring. The duo from Dell—the Inspiron 6400 and Inspiron 640m—came in the familiar all-silver package.

The Toshiba L100 comes up next on the list. The well-contoured body, good use of colour, and cheeky-looking speakers make the Toshiba L100 stand out of the crowd. The Toshiba Tecra A8, on the other hand, relies on conservative styling, and it should be at ease in any corporate environment. The LG laptops sported the most exciting design—white keyboards set in silver bodies. With their tapering design, they are in a league of their own. No wonder they've won the International Forum Design awards!

The HP Pavilion DV2025TU is part of the new breed of laptops that HP is promoting aggressively on TV. Smugness apart, the glossy, high-lustre finish with smart patterns give these new laptops a strong corporate identity. All MSI Megabooks had the same look and feel—elegant, but nothing to rave about.

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OCTOBER 2006



The Dell Inspiron 6400—a fully-loaded Mercedes at the price of a Maruti!

## Ergonomics

The ASUS V6000J features a big and well laid-out keyboard, and the largish touchpad fits flush with the body without any undulation. We liked the ample palm-rest this notebook provides. LG's T1, with its sleek body, good tactile keyboard and super-sensitive touchpad, offers the best possible comfort. The Toshiba L100 offers a good keyboard, but the touchpad doesn't live up to expectations. Despite its bulk, the drooping edges provide good positional support for one's palms. The Toshiba Tecra A8 sports a run-of-the-mill keyboard layout. The touchpad is large, but the buttons are soft and mushy. The Dell duo comes with the same impressive touch and feel as other Dell products, though the touchpad could have been better. As far as the HP Pavilion DV2025TU goes, it is quite similar to the Presario V6120—ergonomically near-perfect, but the touchpad buttons are too mushy.

## Weight

Since these laptops will be used day in and day out, weight plays an important role—too much makes lugging it around a pain. Going by general convention, the “thin and light” category laptops should fall within the 2 and 2.7 kg weight bracket. LG's XNote T1 at 1.9 kg was the lightest, whereas Dell Inspiron 6400 was the heaviest at 3.1 kg. The ASUS V6000J, despite its bulk and metallic body, managed to keep the weight down to an acceptable 2.5 kg.

## Specifications

One brand stood out from the crowd by offering mind-bending configurations—ASUS manages to bundle in the best available hardware in both its laptops. The V6000J sported the latest 2 GHz Core duo processor, a mammoth 2 GB of memory, and NVIDIA's GeForce Go 7400 with 256 MB dedicated memory—what more could one ask for? The ASUS Z35H sported a 1.8 GHz Core Duo processor with 1.5 GB of memory and Intel's onboard graphics adapter.

The laptops from Dell were next with some spell-binding hardware. While the Inspiron 6400 was decked with the 2.16 GHz Core Duo processor, the Inspiron 640m ran a 1.8 GHz processor. Both notebooks were well-supplemented with 1 GB of memory. The Inspiron 6400 had the latest ATI X1400 display adapter with 256 MB of dedicated memory, which should help when playing today's games. The rest of the crowd sported either a Pentium M or Core Duo processor, and 512 MB of memory was common across the board.

With the production cost of 15.4-inch widescreens proving to be more economical than that of regular 15-inch screens, most laptops in the thin and light segment now sport a wide aspect ratio screen. There was a heady mix of 14.1-inch as well as 15.4-inch screens. The Dell Inspiron 6400 comes with a 15.4-inch widescreen that supports a high resolution of 1680 x 1050, meaning lots of desktop space.

Coming to storage, both ASUS and HP generously offered 100 GB hard drives in their laptops. 60 GB was quite common in this category, with